Northwind Labs Travel and Expense Policy

Policy code FIN-POL-03. Version 4.2. Effective 1 April 2026. Owner: Finance Controller. Classification: Internal.

1. Purpose and scope (FIN-01)

This policy sets out how Northwind Labs pays for business travel and work-related spending. It applies to all employees, interns and contractors who spend money on behalf of the company, whether they pay personally and claim it back or use a corporate card.

The general submission deadline and the receipt threshold for expense claims are defined in section 5 of the Employee Handbook. This policy adds the detailed limits, approval routes and payment methods that sit on top of those rules. Where this policy and a team-level guideline disagree, this policy takes precedence.

All amounts are in Indian rupees (INR) unless another currency is stated. Limits are maximums, not allowances. Employees are expected to spend company money as carefully as they would spend their own, and to choose the cheaper option when two options meet the business need equally well.

2. Submitting claims in Spendwise (FIN-02)

All expense claims are filed in Spendwise, the company expense tool, on the web or through the Spendwise mobile app. Each claim must include the business purpose, the project or cost centre code, and a photo or PDF of the receipt wherever a receipt is required. One claim should cover one trip or one purchase, so that approvers can see the full cost of a trip in one place.

Claims that an approver returns for correction must be resubmitted within 10 working days, otherwise Spendwise closes them automatically and they cannot be reopened.

If a receipt is lost, the employee can file a Missing Receipt Declaration (form FIN-F12) instead of the receipt. A Missing Receipt Declaration can be used for items up to INR 2,000, and no more than twice per calendar quarter. Hotel stays always need the itemised hotel bill, so form FIN-F12 cannot be used for accommodation.

Approved claims are paid with the next payroll cycle, as described in the Employee Handbook. Claims approved after the 20th of a month roll over to the following cycle.

3. Approval limits (FIN-03)

Every claim is first approved by the employee's manager. Claims from INR 25,001 to INR 1,00,000 also need approval from the department head, and claims above INR 1,00,000 also need approval from the Finance Controller. Approvals are recorded in Spendwise; approvals given over email or chat are not valid.

Managers cannot approve their own claims, and cannot approve claims submitted by someone they report to. In those cases Spendwise routes the claim to the next level automatically.

Splitting one purchase into several smaller claims to stay under an approval limit is a policy violation, even if every individual claim is otherwise correct.

4. Booking business travel (FIN-04)

All flights, trains and hotels for business travel are booked through TripDesk, the company travel portal. Bookings should be made at least 14 days before departure wherever possible. Bookings made fewer than 7 days before departure need a short justification in TripDesk, which the approver sees together with the fare.

Flight class follows the rules in the Employee Handbook. Seat selection fees of up to INR 1,000 per flight are reimbursable. Paid airport lounge access is not reimbursable. For trips shorter than 500 km, employees should consider train travel in AC 2-tier or AC chair car, which is often faster door to door.

Hotel limits for travel within India are set in the Employee Handbook. Stays of more than 7 consecutive nights in one city should use a serviced apartment booked through TripDesk, because weekly rates are usually lower than hotel rates.

5. International travel (FIN-05)

International trips need approval from the department head before anything is booked, in addition to the manager's approval. The request in TripDesk should state the purpose of the trip, the expected outcome and the estimated total cost.

The hotel cap for international travel is USD 180 per night, rising to USD 250 per night in high-cost cities. The high-cost cities are London, New York, San Francisco, Zurich, Singapore and Tokyo. The Finance Controller reviews this list every year.

The international meal per diem is USD 75 per day and is paid without receipts. The per diem replaces individual meal claims, so an employee who receives a per diem cannot also claim meals for the same day. On the days of departure and return, half of the per diem is paid.

Visa fees for business trips are reimbursable. Northwind Labs covers all international business trips under its group travel insurance; travellers should download their insurance card from TripDesk before departure.

6. Travel advances (FIN-06)

Employees can request a travel advance of up to 80% of the estimated trip cost. Advances are requested in Spendwise at least 5 working days before departure and are paid to the employee's salary account.

Advances must be settled in Spendwise within 15 days of returning from the trip, by submitting the trip's claims against the advance. Any unspent amount is returned to the company. Advances that are not settled on time are recovered from the next salary payment.

7. Meals and entertainment in India (FIN-07)

For domestic business travel, the meal per diem is INR 1,500 per day in metro cities and INR 1,000 per day elsewhere. Metro cities for this policy are Bengaluru, Chennai, Delhi NCR, Hyderabad, Kolkata, Mumbai and Pune.

Client entertainment is capped at INR 3,000 per person, counting both guests and Northwind Labs attendees. The claim must list the name and company of every guest. Alcohol is reimbursable only as part of client entertainment and never on solo travel.

8. Local transport and mileage (FIN-08)

For local travel on business, employees should use app-based cabs or public transport. Individual cab rides above INR 2,000 need a written justification in the claim.

Employees who use their own vehicle for business travel are reimbursed at INR 12 per km for a car and INR 6 per km for a two-wheeler. Tolls and parking fees on business trips are reimbursed separately with receipts. Commuting between home and the employee's regular office is not reimbursable. When work requires an employee to stay in the office after 21:00, the cab ride home is reimbursable.

9. Corporate cards (FIN-09)

Corporate cards are issued to employees who travel on business more than 4 times a year, and to budget owners nominated by their department head. The standard monthly limit on a corporate card is INR 2,00,000. Temporary increases for a specific event can be requested from the Finance Controller.

Cardholders must reconcile every card transaction in Spendwise within 10 days of the statement date, attaching receipts in the same way as for a personal claim. Cards with transactions that remain unreconciled for more than 45 days are suspended until the backlog is cleared.

Personal spending on a corporate card is not allowed. An accidental personal charge must be reported to Finance and repaid within 30 days.

10. Remote work costs (FIN-10)

Employees on the hybrid model can claim internet and mobile costs of up to INR 1,500 per month, with the monthly bill attached. The one-time home office stipend is described in the Employee Handbook and is claimed in Spendwise under the category HOME-SETUP.

11. Software and subscriptions (FIN-11)

Software subscriptions must not be bought with personal money or on a corporate card. All software purchases go through the Procurement team. Any tool that will store Confidential or Restricted data also needs a vendor security review under policy SEC-07 of the Information Security Policy before it is bought.

12. Leave encashment and final settlement (FIN-12)

When an employee leaves Northwind Labs, unused paid leave is encashed in the final settlement, up to a maximum of 30 days, calculated on basic salary. Sick leave is never encashed.

The final settlement is paid within 45 days of the employee's last working day. Outstanding travel advances and unreconciled corporate card transactions are deducted from the final settlement.

13. Items that are never reimbursed (FIN-13)

The following costs are never reimbursed: traffic fines and parking penalties, hotel minibar charges, in-flight purchases, upgrades booked without approval, personal entertainment such as films or games, and lost luggage that was not reported to the airline before leaving the airport.

14. Policy violations (FIN-14)

Suspected misuse is reviewed jointly by the Finance Controller and the People team. Claims found to be false are recovered in full and may lead to disciplinary action, up to and including termination of employment. Employees who are unsure whether a cost is covered should ask in the #finance-help channel before spending.